Nostrian Conquest

Player Manual

A Rust recreation inspired by the classic 1990s BBS door game Esterian Conquest.

Built for localhost and BBS play. A Nostr GameServer path is planned.

All code, UI, and assets in this edition are original. Not affiliated with any original release.

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1. Introduction

Beyond the mapped frontiers of the old Nostrian dominion lies a small galaxy of contested solar systems. The old masters are gone. Their stations are silent, their patrols vanished, and their subjects left with fleets, industry, and enough knowledge to build empires.

You rise as one of the new Star Masters. From a single world and a few small fleets, you must tax, build, scout, bargain, threaten, and strike before rival powers can do the same. Some systems will join your banner willingly. Others will require persuasion from orbit.

Each maintenance marks the passage of a year. In that span, fleets cross the dark between stars, colonies grow or starve, alliances turn cold, and wars are decided by distance, industry, mathematics, and will.

Nostrian Conquest is a Rust recreation inspired by the classic 1990s BBS door game Esterian Conquest. All code, UI, and assets in this edition are original. It is not affiliated with any original release.

In homage to the 1990s door-game pioneers and to the ancient dreamers, strategists, and storytellers whose visions of galactic dominion still light the way among these stars.

2. Connecting to a Game

2.1. Three Ways to Play

Nostrian Conquest has three practical ways to play.

The direct path is **Localhost**. In that mode you or your sysop runs `nc-game` directly on the same machine. Use this for solo play, hotseat testing, and trusted same-machine sessions. If you are setting that up yourself, see the **Sysop Manual** section **Localhost Session Setup**.

The classic path is **BBS**. In that mode you log into a bulletin board with a terminal client and launch the game from the doors menu. The sysop stages `nc-door` behind the BBS. If you are the sysop, see the **Sysop Manual** section **BBS Door Setup**.

The planned network path is **Nostr GameServer**. That path is still under development. For now, treat localhost and BBS as the normal ways to play.

2.2. Finding New Games

If you are joining a private localhost campaign, your sysop tells you which machine and player slot to use.

If you are joining a BBS campaign, connect to the bulletin board normally and launch the game from the doors menu. Your sysop may reserve a seat for your BBS alias, or may leave open seats available from the first-time join menu.

If you are waiting for the Nostr GameServer path, watch the main project docs. It is planned, but it is not the normal join path yet.

2.3. Joining a Game

For localhost play, the normal direct launch is:

```
nc-game --dir /path/to/mygame --player 1
```

Your sysop may give you a different player number or run the command for you on the local machine.

For BBS play, the sysop launches `nc-door` from the board software and the caller enters through the normal first-time or returning-player flow inside the game. If your BBS alias is reserved for a seat, the door routes you there automatically.

3. Quick Start: Gameplay Basics

3.1. Your Objective

Your objective is simple: become Emperor by dominating rivals or eliminating every serious threat.

You begin with one planet at 100 production and four fleets — two carrying an ETAC and cruiser for colonization, and two lone destroyers for screening and early contact. Set a tax rate around 50–65% on your homeworld, and use the revenue to build ships, armies, batteries, and starbases. Keep taxes low on new colonies so they develop quickly.

Each round represents one year. You submit orders during the year, and maintenance resolves all empires simultaneously on an internal 52-week timeline. Reports are dated as `Stardate WK/YYYY` (week/year).

3.2. Turn Progression

There is no "End Turn" button. You set your economy, assign your missions, and log off. The sysop or schedule decides when maintenance runs. When it does, the game resolves every empire at once, advances the year, and writes your next set of reports.

3.3. Assets You Can Build

The table below lists everything your planets can produce. **AS** is Attack Strength (firepower) and **DS** is Defense Strength (hull/shields).

Item	Cost	Size	Speed	AS	DS	Purpose
Destroyer	05	S	6	10	05	Fast combat, screening, defense
Cruiser	15	M	5	30	30	Balanced combat
Battleship	45	L	4	90	100	Heavy combat
Scout	15	S	6	00	10	Reconnaissance
Troop Transport	05	M	5	00	10	Deliver armies
ETAC	20	L	3	00	20	Colonize raw planets (reusable)
Ground Battery	20	L	–	90	20	Planetary defense
Army	02	S	–	10	10	Surface defense and capture
Starbase	50	L	1	100	120	Defense, production boost

3.4. Fleet Missions (Summary)

Fleet missions fall into three classes. *One-shot* missions travel, act, and then fall back to Hold Position. *Persistent* missions stay in force until you replace them or game rules cancel them. *Hostile* missions go to the target world and wait. The assault happens on the *next* maintenance tick after arrival, not at once.

No	Mission	Type	Requirements	On Arrival / Completion
00	Hold position	Persistent	Any ships	Idle at current position
01	Move to sector	One-shot	Any	Reverts to Hold on arrival
02	Seek Home	One-shot	Any	Reverts to Hold; retargets if destination captured
03	Patrol	Persistent	Any	Patrols sector continuously
04	Guard starbase	Persistent	Combat ships	Escorts starbase continuously
05	Guard/blockade world	Persistent	Combat ships	Blockades world continuously
06	Bombard world	Hostile	Combat ships	Bombards when in orbit at tick start
07	Invade world	Hostile	Combat + loaded transports	Invades when in orbit at tick start
08	Blitz world	Hostile	Loaded transports (combat recommended)	Blitzes when in orbit at tick start
09	View	One-shot	Any	Scans from system edge, reverts to Hold
10	Scout sector	Persistent	At least one scout	Reports each turn while on station
11	Scout system	Persistent	At least one scout	Reports each turn while on station
12	Colonize world	One-shot	At least one ETAC	Colonizes if unowned; ETAC survives for reuse
13	Join Fleet	Persistent	Any	Chases host until merge; abandons if host lost
14	Rendezvous	Persistent	Any	Waits at sector; lowest fleet ID becomes host
15	Salvage	One-shot	Any	Scraps ships for ~50% value, reverts to Hold

4. Forces at Your Command

You control five major force types: planets, ships, starbases, armies, and ground batteries.

4.1. Planets

Planets are the foundation of your empire. Each one has a **Potential Production** — the ceiling it can reach at full efficiency, ranging from 10 to 150 across the galaxy — and a **Production**, which is what the planet can actually deliver right now. Production grows toward Potential over time, and the speed of that growth depends heavily on your tax rate.

Taxes convert Production into spendable build points each year. See Section 5 for the full tax rate, growth, and starbase economics model.

4.2. Ships

Ships operate in fleets. A fleet always moves at the speed of its slowest member and can hold anywhere from one to **3,000 ships** of mixed types.

Ship Type	Cost	Speed	Size	AS	DS	Tactical Role
Destroyer	05	6	S	10	05	Fast, cheap screen. Escapes heavy fleets. Good for fast response and interception.
Cruiser	15	5	M	30	30	Balanced fighter. About 3x the power of a destroyer.
Battleship	45	4	L	90	100	Heavy firepower anchor. About 3x the power of a cruiser. Slow but durable.
Scout	15	6	S	00	10	Stealthy spy. A lone scout is hardest to detect.
Transport	05	5	M	00	10	Unarmed. Carries one army. Essential for conquest.
ETAC	20	3	L	00	20	Colony ship. Reusable — survives colonization.

4.3. Starbases

Starbases are large space fortresses (Cost: 50, AS: 100, DS: 120). In orbit, they strengthen a world's defense and economy. They help weak colonies grow at sensible tax rates, and they let a planet spend up to **5x** its Production in one turn when enough points have been saved (see Section 5). They are not a license to tax a world to death. In deep space they serve as watch posts with slightly more firepower than a battleship, but they crawl at speed 1.

Unlike ships, starbases do not belong to fleets. You commission them one at a time from stardock and move them through the **Starbase Command** submenu. Older docs sometimes say a starbase is "hauled." In practice, that just means moving a very slow unit. You may order combat fleets to escort a starbase with Mission 4 (Guard Starbase), but the starbase remains its own unit.

NOTE: Starbases must be commissioned from stardock before they can be moved or provide orbital benefits. An uncommissioned starbase sitting in stardock has no effect.

4.4. Ground Forces

Armies (Cost: 2, AS: 10, DS: 10) defend your planets from invasion and are the only way to capture enemy worlds. Each troop transport carries one army, and a successful invasion requires landing enough armies to overwhelm the defending garrison.

Ground Batteries (Cost: 20, AS: 90, DS: 20) are immobile land-based cannons that offer massive firepower per cost — roughly equal to a battleship at less than half the price. During an invasion, all batteries must be destroyed before transports can land. During a blitz, surviving batteries fire directly on descending transports, inflicting heavy losses. If a planet is captured via blitz, any surviving batteries transfer intact to the new owner.

5. Economy and Taxes

Your empire runs on production. Every owned planet generates tax revenue each maintenance cycle, and that revenue pays for ships, defenses, and expansion. Managing the tension between short-term revenue and long-term growth is one of the deepest strategic challenges in the game.

5.1. Key Terms

Every planet has a **Potential Production** — the maximum productive capacity it can ever reach — and a **Production**, which is what it can deliver right now. Production grows toward Potential over time. Your empire's **Empire Revenue** is the sum of tax revenue across all your planets. Any revenue a planet does not spend accumulates on it as its **Treasury** — the reserve of saved production points available to fund future builds. Each turn, how much of that treasury a planet can actually spend is limited by its **build capacity**; that per-turn spending limit is the planet's **Budget**.

5.2. Tax Revenue

The tax rate is empire-wide: you set one rate for all your planets. Revenue per planet per year is a fixed percentage of Production, and your empire's Empire Revenue is the sum of that revenue across all owned planets. See Section 11 for the exact formula.

5.3. Growth Toward Potential

Each maintenance turn, every owned planet grows toward its Potential. Lower taxes grow faster. A planet at 30% tax develops far faster than one at 60%. Growth also slows as the planet nears its ceiling. Even at punishing tax rates, a planet below Potential still gains at least 1 point per year.

Growth is based on the gap to Potential and the remaining tax headroom. See Section 11 for the exact formula.

5.4. The 65% Tax Threshold

> **WARNING:** Setting taxes above **65%** can directly *reduce* Production on your planets, not just slow growth.

Below 65%, growth is always positive — lower is faster. Above 65%, a penalty kicks in that actively damages Production. A commissioned starbase does **not** remove this danger. Its value is that it helps young colonies grow faster before you reach punitive tax rates, and it still preserves the powerful build-capacity bonus described below.

The recommended early-game rate is around 50–65%. Drop taxes on new colonies to accelerate their development. See Section 11 for the exact penalty and yearly update formulas.

5.5. Starbase Economic Effects

A commissioned starbase in orbit provides two major benefits. First, the planet's yearly production growth gets a strong boost when taxes are modest — the full bonus applies at **50% tax or lower**, then tapers away as taxes climb toward **65%**. This means underdeveloped

planets with starbases catch up significantly faster when you are managing them sensibly, but the bonus is not meant to offset punitive taxes. Second, the planet gains a **build capacity multiplier** — it can spend up to **5x** its Production on builds in a single turn, drawing from its treasury. Without a starbase, a planet can only spend up to 1x its Production per turn. See Section 11 for the exact bonus taper and build-capacity formulas.

> **NOTE:** These bonuses require an active, commissioned starbase in orbit — not an uncommissioned starbase sitting in stardock.

5.6. Treasury

Tax revenue that a planet does not spend accumulates in its **Treasury** — the planet's savings reserve. The treasury is what allows starbase worlds to execute large builds: up to 5x Production in a single turn. Each turn, a planet's **Budget** is the lesser of its treasury and its build capacity. That is what the build screen shows as **BUDGET** — how many production points remain uncommitted this turn. When maintenance processes a build queue, only the points actually spent that year are deducted from the treasury; unfinished builds keep their remaining cost for later turns.

5.7. Newly Colonized Planets

A freshly colonized planet starts with Production far below its Potential and with no treasury. It does not collect revenue or growth on the same maintenance turn that establishes the colony. Growth begins on the next maintenance turn. Each year growth is applied first and tax revenue is then credited on the grown Production, so at moderate tax rates most colonies have a small budget after their first full turn. Very small worlds, or colonies under low taxes, can still sit at zero budget for a turn or more because their revenue rounds down to zero. Low taxes still develop new colonies fastest; they just fill the treasury more slowly at first.

5.8. Conquered Planets

When you capture an enemy planet by invasion or blitz, the planet's industry needs approximately **two turns** before it is fully converted and begins producing tax revenue for your empire. Plan your logistics around this delay.

6. Combat Mechanics

Battle reports are short, but the fighting is not random brawling. Combat is simultaneous and rule-driven. Both sides fire in the same round. Losses are then applied. This keeps battle outcomes clear, severe, and consistent.

6.1. The Rules of Battle

There is no "first strike" advantage. Each round, the total **Attack Strength (AS)** of each fleet is calculated and inflicted upon the enemy at the same instant. Rounds repeat until one side is destroyed, disengages, or only one hostile force remains.

Damage reduces ships from "Nominal" to "Crippled" status before destroying them. All nominal ships must be crippled before any crippled ship is destroyed, and surviving crippled ships are repaired automatically after battle. Hits always target the combat line first — destroyers, cruisers, battleships, and starbases. Scouts, transports, and ETACs are protected as long as any combat-line ships remain, which means your non-combat vessels survive as long as your warships hold the line.

Mixed fleets containing destroyers, cruisers, *and* battleships receive a **combined arms bonus**. Always mix your composition when you can. A defending starbase at its own world gives the defender another combat bonus. In a draw, the defender wins. See Section 12 for the exact ROE thresholds, combat values, force-ratio columns, CRT table, and assault formulas.

6.2. Who Fights Whom

Your fleets attack the fleets of any player you have declared to be an enemy, wherever they meet them — in deep space or at one of your guarded systems — as far as their ROE allows. They also attack any other player's fleet that **enters one of your solar systems**, or that enters a world your fleet is blockading, whether or not you are at war with him. Starting such a fight makes the two empires enemies.

A fleet enters a solar system when its mission takes it in to the planet: Guard Starbase, Guard/Blockade World, Bombard, Invade, Blitz, and Scout Solar System. Every other mission — Move, Patrol, Scout Sector, Hold, Join, Rendezvous, Seek Home — keeps the fleet in the sector's deep space, and View World scans from the system's edge before backing off. A foreign fleet in deep space is reported, but it is not attacked unless you have declared its owner an enemy.

Only fleets that actually trade fire take part in a battle. A neutral fleet that happens to share the sector is not involved, and if neither side can fire — say, an enemy scout meets an enemy transport fleet — both report the contact and carry on with their missions.

6.3. Tactical Roles and Split Fire

Combat is more than just a numbers game. Different ship classes perform specific tactical roles based on how they deliver fire. Hits generated by a task force are split into two pools:

Suppression Fire (Cruisers and Battleships): **These heavy vessels provide volume and suppression. Their hits are dispersed across the enemy fleet, reducing nominal ships**

to a crippled **state. This effectively knocks enemy guns offline and wins the immediate field, but it does not always result in permanent kills. Execution Fire (Destroyers and Starbases):** These units use **focus fire** to eliminate specific targets. Their hits bypass the crippled state and allocate directly to the **destroyed** pool, paying the full 2x DS cost to blow ships up one by one.

This creates a deadly pair. Heavy ships soften the line. Destroyers and starbases finish it.

> **NOTE:** All planetary return fire from ground batteries is treated as **Execution Fire**. Fortified worlds do not "soften" an attacker; they destroy him.

6.4. Fleet Limits

A fleet can contain as few as one ship and as many as **3,000 ships** of mixed types. A fleet always moves at the speed of its slowest member.

6.5. Rules of Engagement (ROE)

You assign an ROE level (0–10) to control when your fleet voluntarily engages hostile forces. ROE is a fixed commitment rule based on force ratios, not chance.

Before any fire is exchanged, your fleet performs a **pre-combat sensor check**. If the enemy force is overwhelming and violates his ROE, the commander will abort the engagement and "seek home" immediately. This clean retreat happens before the battle begins, allowing him to scout safely without being forced into a suicidal withdrawal exchange.

Note: Sensor checks do not trigger if you are forced into engagement (such as entering a defended system) or if your fleet is on patrol.

Guards, starbases, and fleets at their own world are anchored to their system. If an enemy is only passing through the sector and their ROE does not favor a fight, they hold formation: they stay on station, keep their orders, and fire only if the enemy attacks them. Against a fleet that enters the system, they always fight.

The full ROE threshold table is collected in Section 12.

Non-combat fleets (scouts, transports, ETACs only) are treated as ROE 0 automatically.

6.6. Withdrawal and Retreat

> **IMPORTANT:** Low ROE does not guarantee safety once combat begins.

If you choose to engage (or are forced to), your fleet is committed to the battle for a minimum of **three rounds**. ROE-based bailing is disabled until Round 4. This ensures that fleets trade meaningful blows before one side loses his nerve.

A fleet that breaks off after Round 3 does not escape cleanly. It suffers a **withdrawal exchange** — the enemy fires on your retreating fleet, and your fleet fires back at reduced effectiveness. Only after absorbing that exchange does the fleet actually retreat and abort its current mission. After each round of combat from Round 4 onward, surviving fleets re-check

their ROE. If the post-loss ratio no longer meets his threshold, the commander attempts to disengage and suffers the withdrawal exchange.

6.7. Planetary Combat

When fleets attack planets through bombardment, invasion, or blitz, different rules apply. Ground batteries are the planet's shield wall — while they stand, they draw orbital fire and shoot back, protecting armies, production, and industry behind them. Only combat ships — destroyers, cruisers, and battleships — contribute bombardment firepower. Scouts, transports, and ETACs do not.

> **WARNING:** Planetary defenses use **focus fire**. Hits from ground batteries bypass the crippled state and directly destroy ships, making them far more lethal than dispersed ship-to-ship fire. A commander who brings a large fleet to orbit a fortified world will find his ships being picked off one by one by concentrated ground fire.

Each bombardment turn resolves three rounds of fire. In rounds 1 and 2, your ships trade fire with the planet's batteries. Hits land on stardock contents first, then batteries, but armies, stored goods, and factories are shielded. In round 3, if all batteries have been destroyed, your remaining firepower breaks through to armies, stored goods, and factories. If batteries still stand, round 3 is another suppression exchange and the planet's vulnerable assets survive another turn.

Planetary targets have defense strength just like ships. Destroying a ground battery takes 20 hits, an army 10 hits, and a ship in the stardock as many hits as its own DS. A lone cruiser cannot level a fortified world in a single volley.

This means a well-defended planet takes sustained bombardment over multiple turns before you touch its production. Build batteries to buy time; bring heavy fleets to break through faster.

See Section 7 for the detailed mechanics of bombardment, invasion, and blitz missions. The exact bombardment weights, batteries-only return-fire rule, and combat tables are in Section 12.

7. Missions and Orders

A fleet always has exactly one standing order. If you issue a new order before maintenance, it replaces whatever the fleet was doing. Missions fall into three categories. *One-shot* missions cause the fleet to travel, perform an action, and revert to Hold Position — you must issue new orders afterward. *Persistent* missions remain active until you replace them or game rules invalidate them (for example, a Join mission is abandoned if the host fleet is destroyed). *Hostile* missions send the fleet to a target world where it waits; the assault executes on the *next* maintenance tick after arrival, not immediately. Plan accordingly.

No	Mission	Type	Description
00	None	Persistent	Hold position at current location.
01	Move Fleet	One-shot	Travel to a specified sector, then revert to Hold.
02	Seek Home	One-shot	Return to nearest owned planet; retargets if that planet is captured en route.
03	Patrol	Persistent	Move within sector deep space to intercept enemies.
04	Guard Starbase	Persistent	Escort a starbase; fight alongside it.
05	Blockade	Persistent	Prevent access to a planet. Stops enemy launches and landings.
06	Bombard	Hostile	Damage factories, batteries, armies, stardock contents, and production.
07	Invade	Hostile	Suppress batteries, bombard, then land armies. Requires loaded transports.
08	Blitz	Hostile	Drop armies immediately, dodging batteries. High army risk.
09	View	One-shot	Long-range scan of owner and production from system edge.
10	Scout Sector	Persistent	Passive stealth surveillance of sector deep space (requires Scout).
11	Scout System	Persistent	Active spy mission into a solar system (requires Scout).
12	Colonize	One-shot	Terraform and claim unowned planet (requires ETAC). ETAC survives for reuse.
13	Join Fleet	Persistent	Chase and merge with target fleet. Abandons if host is destroyed.
14	Rendezvous	Persistent	Meet other fleets at sector. Lowest fleet ID becomes host.
15	Salvage	One-shot	Scrap ships at planet for ~50% of build cost.

7.1. Mission Details

7.1.1. One-Shot Missions

Mission 1: Move to Sector. A simple transit order. The fleet travels to the destination sector at the speed of its slowest ship, then stops and reverts to Hold Position. You must issue new orders if you want it to do anything else.

Mission 2: Seek Home. The fleet travels to the nearest planet you own. If that planet is captured while the fleet is en route, it automatically redirects to the next nearest friendly planet. On arrival, it reverts to Hold Position.

Mission 9: View a World. A safe, long-range scan. The fleet approaches the edge of the target system, scans for owner and production data, and immediately backs off into deep space. Because it never enters the system, it does not provoke the owner's defenses unless he has declared you an enemy. It reverts to Hold Position after reporting.

Mission 12: Colonize a World. Requires at least one ETAC (Environmental Transformation And Colonization ship). If the planet is unowned, it is terraformed and claimed. The new colony starts with one garrison army, no treasury, and very low current production. It does not receive revenue or growth until later maintenance turns, and then develops faster under low taxes. The ETAC is not consumed — it survives and can colonize additional planets. If the planet is already owned, the ETAC aborts, reports the owner's identity and production potential, writes that partial result into your Total Planet Database, and waits for new orders.

Mission 15: Salvage. The fleet travels to the specified planet and scraps its ships for approximately **50%** of the original build cost, returned to that planet's treasury. It reverts to Hold Position after scrapping.

7.1.2. Persistent Standing Missions

Mission 0: Hold Position. The default idle state. The fleet stays at its current location and takes defensive action based on ROE if hostile fleets approach.

Mission 3: Patrol a Sector. The fleet moves within deep space to intercept enemies passing through. If the patrol spots anything, it sends a report, and it engages based on your ROE settings. The mission remains active until you assign a new one.

Mission 4: Guard Starbase. The fleet escorts a starbase and fights alongside it. Be aware that if your fleet has a high ROE, it may break formation to chase enemy fleets passing through the sector, leaving the starbase temporarily vulnerable. A guard whose ROE does not favor the chase holds formation and lets passing enemies go, but any fleet that enters the system is engaged.

Mission 5: Guard/Blockade a World. A strategy of denial. The blockade stops enemy fleets from using the planet, intercepts ships launching from stardock, and paralyzes the enemy's ability to deploy forces from that world. Any fleet that tries to enter a world you are blockading is attacked. Blockading another player's world takes your fleet into his solar system, so his defenses will fight it. It remains active until you assign a new mission.

Missions 10 and 11: Scout Sector / Scout System. Both require at least one Scout ship, and a fleet consisting of a single Scout is the least likely to be detected. Scout Sector is a passive, stealthy patrol — unlike Mission 3, the fleet will not engage enemies but instead relies on stealth to observe traffic without being seen. Scout System is an active spy run where the Scout penetrates the system to report on ground batteries, armies, current production, stardock contents, and orbiting fleets; entering the system means the owner's defenses will attack it. Both are persistent missions: the fleet remains on station and generates a new report each maintenance turn for as long as it stays at its assigned sector. If you identify an **In Civil Disorder** fleet in a system that still belongs to that disorder state, the Total Planet Database marks that world's owner as `ICD` even before a full scout/view report is earned.

Missions 13 and 14: Fleet Coordination. Mission 13 (Join Fleet) causes the fleet to chase a specific host fleet and merge with it when they meet. If the host is destroyed before they rendezvous, the joining fleet abandons the mission. Mission 14 (Rendezvous) sends multiple fleets to a sector where the fleet with the lowest Fleet ID becomes the host of the combined force. The rendezvous point remains active so additional fleets can keep merging there.

7.1.3. Hostile (Delayed-Resolution) Missions

> **IMPORTANT:** Hostile missions require the fleet to be **in orbit at the start of maintenance** to execute. A fleet that arrives at the target world this turn will carry out its assault **next turn**. This one-turn delay is a critical tactical consideration — defend accordingly.

A fleet in orbit on a hostile mission has entered the owner's solar system, so his fleets and starbases engage it on arrival. Only one kind of assault strikes a world each turn, in the order Blitz, Invade, Bombard. If you have fleets on different assault missions at the same world, only those on that turn's assault take part; the others keep their orders and cargo and strike on a later turn.

Mission 6: Bombard a World. Only destroyers, cruisers, and battleships contribute bombardment firepower — scouts, transports, and ETACs do not. Each turn your fleet bombards, the engine runs three rounds of fire. In rounds 1 and 2, your ships exchange fire with ground batteries — hits destroy stardock contents first, then batteries, but armies, stored goods, and industry are shielded behind the battery wall. Each battery takes 20 hits to destroy, each army 10, and each docked ship its own DS. In round 3, if batteries have been eliminated, your firepower breaks through to armies, stored goods, and finally industry. If batteries still stand after round 2, round 3 is another suppression exchange and the planet's production survives. Bombardment persists each turn until you issue new orders. Use it to grind down a world's defenses before invasion, or to deny resources to an enemy over time.

Mission 7: Invade a World. A three-stage deliberate assault. First, combat ships exchange fire with ground batteries in orbital suppression — transports cannot land until all batteries are destroyed. Once batteries are gone, surviving combat ships fire on the defending armies to soften resistance before landing. Softening fire is matched against the garrison's full strength (10 AS per army), and each army destroyed takes 10 hits. Unlike bombardment, invasion softening targets armies only — industry and stored goods are preserved because

the goal is to capture the planet with its production intact. However, orbital softening can destroy at most **half** of the defending army stack; at least half of the original defenders must still be fought on the ground. Finally, transports land their armies and the ground battle continues in repeated simultaneous rounds until one side is wiped out. The defender fights from cover with a defensive edge, and ground combat cannot end in a draw — if a final exchange would wipe out both sides, the larger force entering that exchange is treated as the winner, with exact equality favoring the defender. Capture requires destroying all defending armies, after which your surviving armies become the new garrison. Conquered planets need approximately two turns before they are fully converted to your production.

Mission 8: Blitz a World. Transports drop armies immediately in a fast assault that bypasses the full orbital suppression sequence. Escorting combat ships provide brief cover fire, but surviving batteries fire directly on descending transports, causing heavy losses. A fleet of loaded TT⋆ may attempt a blitz even without escorting warships, but then it brings no orbital firepower of its own. Enemy non-combat ships do not prevent that attempt, but enemy combat control of orbit or a defending starbase blocks the landing entirely. Once on the surface, armies fight in repeated simultaneous rounds until one side is wiped out, and the defender receives a defensive bonus throughout the ground battle. If you take the planet, surviving ground batteries transfer intact to your control. The blitz preserves industry but carries high risk to your armies and transports — a 2:1 army advantage or better is recommended. Choose blitz when the planet has few or no batteries and you want to preserve its industry, or when speed matters more than casualties.

8. Interface and Commands

The game is organized around four primary menus. From the **Main Menu**, you access General Command (**G**) for autopilot, diplomacy, and reports; Planet Command (**P**) for economy and production; Fleet Command (**F**) for ship movement and missions; Information Database (**I**) to review known planet data; and View Starmap (**V**) for a graphic map of the galaxy.

8.1. Visual Themes

The `nc-game` client supports several visual themes. In a local session, open **C>olor Theme** from the Main Menu or First Time Menu to choose one. Your last local choice is remembered for that empire in that campaign.

In BBS door mode, the game keeps the classic **A>nsi color ON/OFF** toggle. Each session starts from the `mag16` theme so ANSI16 terminals stay stable. Press **A** to switch between that view and monochrome for the current session. Saved local theme preferences do not apply in door mode.

8.2. General Command

General Command handles empire-wide business. Autopilot (**A**) lets the computer mind your defenses if you miss turns. By default, autopilot turns on after three missed turns. Your first real return that year — logging into `nc-game`, entering through `nc-door`, or submitting a valid turn file — turns that inactivity autopilot back off. Manual autopilot stays on until you change it yourself. Diplomacy (**E**) lets you mark other empires as Neutral or Enemy. Messages (**C**) lets you write to other empires.

To keep messaging civil, you may send no more than three messages to any single opponent per turn. In a four-player game, for example, that is up to twelve outgoing messages in a turn. Messages and reports are never automatically purged — they accumulate in your inbox across turns until you remove them yourself. The inbox supports type and year filters to help you find older items, and pressing **D** on a selected item prompts for deletion, defaulting to yes. General Command also offers a bulk delete to clear all messages at once. New reports and messages from the most recent maintenance turn are presented one by one through the scrolling intro review when you log in, giving you another opportunity to read and delete before reaching the main menu.

The empire rankings table shows each joined empire in one of three states: **Active**, **MIA**, or **Defeated**. **MIA** means inactivity autopilot is currently running because that player missed three consecutive turns. **Defeated** means the empire has been eliminated from active command.

8.3. Defeat, Recovery, and Victory

Losing your last planet does not always defeat you immediately. If you still have a recovery path, you remain **Active** and receive a **three-turn recovery window** to reclaim a world. A recovery path means at least one loaded troop transport (`TT*`) somewhere in your surviving fleets, or at least one ETAC while any unowned planet still exists anywhere on the map. If you retake or colonize a world before the window expires, the countdown clears and your empire continues normally.

If your last recovery force is destroyed while you are planetless, or if the three-turn recovery window expires first, your empire becomes **Defeated**. Fleet Command sends you a final defeat report, and you receive one last review-only login so you can read the closing reports and messages. After that final review, you may no longer enter the campaign.

When you eliminate another empire, Fleet Command reports that you delivered the final blow. This is separate from overall game victory. The game ends only when one empire is recognized as Emperor and no other serious contender remains. At that point every still-playable empire receives a game-over report naming the victor. The winner may continue to log in in **survey mode** to inspect the final state of the galaxy, but may not issue orders or submit turns. All other players receive one final review-only pass and are then blocked from further play.

8.4. Planet Command

Planet Command controls your economy and ground operations. Tax (**T**) sets the empire-wide tax rate. From the main Planet Command menu, Scorch Earth (**S**) destroys your own industry to deny it to an invader. Build (**B**) spends production points on ships, defenses, or starbases. Commission (**C**) assigns newly built ships from stardock into active fleets. **Mass Commission** (**M**) commissions every ship and starbase currently waiting in stardock. Load and Unload (**L** / **U**) move armies between the planet surface and troop transports.

The **Planet List** is the fast row-centric operations screen for owned worlds. Once you open it, the highlighted planet becomes the working row for the most common actions: Build (**B**), Display Queue (**D**), Abort Builds (**A**), Mass Commission (**M**), Commission (**C**), Load / Unload armies (**L** / **U**), and Scorch Earth (**X**). On that screen, **S** is reserved for **Sort**, while **I** or **Enter** opens planet information for the selected row. Owned-planet information includes the planet's **Budget** as well as its **Treasury**.

8.5. Fleet Command

Fleet Command controls your ships in space. Mission (**O**) assigns missions 0–15. ROE (**C**) changes a fleet's rules of engagement. Merge (**M**) combines fleets that are in the same sector. Transfer (**T**) moves individual ships between fleets.

The **Fleet List** is also the bulk-fleet work screen. It now includes a **Sel** column. Press **Space** on a fleet row to check or uncheck it. When one or more fleets are checked, **O** assigns one mission to the checked set, **C** changes their shared ROE or speed, **M** merges the checked fleets using the lowest Fleet ID as the host, and **T** opens ship transfer for a checked pair. Row-based commands such as **Review**, **ETA**, **Detach**, **Load**, and **Unload** still use the highlighted fleet.

8.6. Building and Commissioning

Each planet has a **10-slot build queue**. During maintenance, a planet processes as many queued build points as its current per-turn build capacity allows. Small orders may finish in one maintenance turn, while larger ones can stay queued across multiple years until the remaining cost reaches zero. As enough points are applied to complete individual units, ships and starbases move to **Stardock** — a holding area on the planet where they sit idle and

vulnerable until commissioned — even if other units from the same order remain queued. Ships are commissioned into numbered fleets, while starbases are commissioned individually and managed through their own Starbase Command submenu. Armies and ground batteries, by contrast, deploy directly to the planet surface and do not pass through stardock.

A planet without a starbase can spend up to its Production in a single turn. A planet with an orbiting starbase can spend up to **5x** its Production, drawing from its treasury (see Section 5.6). The build screen shows **BUDGET** — your treasury capped by build capacity, minus what you have already committed this turn.

> **NOTE:** The build queue, stardock, and treasury are all linked. If stardock is full for a given unit type, that slot stops drawing points. Blocked slots do not drain your treasury — but they also do not free capacity for other work. Commission your ships promptly to keep the pipeline moving.

> **WARNING:** Troop transports are built empty. You must manually load armies onto them before sending them into battle.

> **WARNING:** Stardock contents are a prime target for enemy bombardment. Commission your ships promptly or risk losing them before they ever see combat.

> **NOTE:** The starmap can be exported as a TXT file, a CSV grid, and a CSV details sheet for offline planning. Local Rust-client play can export it directly from the in-game starmap view, and BBS operators can hand the exported files to players out of band if they want offline planning aids.

9. Strategy

9.1. Early Game: The Land Grab

The opening turns are a race for territory. ETACs are your most valuable early asset — grab every raw planet you can find before your rivals do. Push lone destroyers forward as pickets to make early contact, but use true Scouts when you need stealth reconnaissance. Keep your tax rate at or below 65% to avoid damaging production, and drop taxes even lower on new colonies so they develop quickly. The temptation to tax at 100% for immediate cash is strong, but it cripples long-term growth.

9.2. Mid-Game: Consolidation

Once the easy colonies are claimed, the game shifts to fortification and intelligence. Build starbases on your best worlds to boost both defense and production capacity. Never attack a planet blindly — use Scout ships on Mission 11 to count enemy batteries and garrison strength before committing forces. This is the "get tough" phase: when raw planets are gone, the only way to grow is war.

9.3. Late Game: Total War

In the endgame, fleet composition and denial matter more than raw numbers. Mix destroyers, cruisers, and battleships in every fleet to trigger the combined arms bonus and distribute damage across hull types — pure battleship fleets are expensive and miss the bonus. If you cannot hold a planet, scorch it. If you cannot take a planet, blockade or bombard it into uselessness. And in a 25-player galaxy, diplomacy is not optional: you cannot fight everyone at once. Form alliances, even temporary ones, and break them only when the timing is right.

10. Historical Context

The BBS Era (1990–1992)

The original game emerged between 1990 and 1992 as a "door game" for Bulletin Board Systems. In an era before the World Wide Web, players dialed into servers over phone lines to play strategy games against dozens of strangers. Everything ran through rigid 80x25 text terminals — every menu, every star map, every battle report squeezed into that tiny viewport. It stood alongside classics like *TradeWars 2002* and *Solar Realms Elite*, but was distinguished by its depth, its hands-off design, and the sheer scale of its campaigns.

What Made It Special

Most multiplayer games of the era demanded constant attention. Esterian Conquest was different. You checked in once a day, submitted your orders, and went about your life. Overnight, the engine processed every empire simultaneously — fleets moved, economies grew, battles resolved, and alliances were tested. When you logged in the next day, a stack of reports was waiting. Campaigns ran for months, and the stories they produced — surprise invasions, desperate blockades, betrayals at the worst possible moment — were the kind that stuck with players for years.

The Rust Port (2026)

This edition rebuilds the game for modern machines while keeping the old campaign rhythm intact. The core rules were recovered from the original game and manuals, then rewritten into a clear modern engine. Where the old game hid things behind opaque internals, this edition uses explicit documented rules instead. If you played the original game on a BBS, it should feel familiar. If you are new to it, this manual gives you the rules straight.

11. Appendix A: Economy Formula Reference

This appendix collects the exact economy formulas in one place.

11.1. Yearly Tax Revenue

```
revenue = floor(present_production * tax_rate / 100)
```

Your empire's Empire Revenue is the sum of this value across all owned planets. Maintenance credits revenue after the year's growth and any high-tax penalty, so `present_production` here is the updated value.

11.2. Base Growth Toward Potential

```
gap = potential_production - present_production
tax_headroom = 100 - min(tax_rate, 95)
base_growth = ceil(gap * tax_headroom / 400)
```

Then clamp the result so a planet below Potential always grows by at least `1` and never grows by more than the remaining `gap`.

11.3. High-Tax Penalty Above 65%

```
if tax_rate > 65:
penalty = ceil(present_production * (tax_rate - 65) / 500)
```

Final yearly Production is:

```
present_production = min(potential_production, present_production + growth) -
penalty
```

11.4. Starbase Growth Bonus

A commissioned starbase boosts growth at low and moderate tax rates, but the bonus tapers away completely by `65%`.

```
bonus_percent = 50 if tax_rate <= 50
bonus_percent = floor((65 - tax_rate) * 50 / 15) if 50 < tax_rate < 65
bonus_percent = 0 if tax_rate >= 65
growth = base_growth + ceil(base_growth * bonus_percent / 100)
```

11.5. Build Capacity, Treasury, and Budget

Per-turn build capacity is:

```
build_capacity = present_production without starbase
build_capacity = present_production * 5 with starbase
```

A planet's **treasury** accumulates unspent production points across turns. Each turn, the **budget** is capped by build capacity:

```
budget = min(treasury, build_capacity)
```

The BUDGET field on the build screen shows how many points remain after committed queue entries are subtracted. Maintenance deducts only the build points actually processed that year; any remaining build cost stays queued for later turns, and blocked builds do not consume the treasury.

12. Appendix B: Combat Tables and Formula Reference

This appendix collects the combat reference tables in one place.

12.1. Rules of Engagement Thresholds

ROE	Force Requirement	Behavior
00	Never engage	**Pacifist**: Flee from all hostile fleets.
01	Enemy defenseless	**Opportunist**: Engage only if the enemy has no combat capability.
02	4:1 or better	**Very Cautious**: Engage only with overwhelming advantage.
03	3:1 or better	**Cautious**: Engage only with strong advantage.
04	2:1 or better	**Favorable**: Engage with clear superiority.
05	3:2 or better	**Confident**: Engage with moderate advantage.
06	1:1 or better	**Balanced**: Engage equal or inferior forces.
07	Even if outgunned 3:2	**Bold**: Accept moderate disadvantage.
08	Even if outgunned 2:1	**Aggressive**: Accept significant disadvantage.
09	Even if outgunned 3:1	**Reckless**: Accept severe disadvantage.
10	Always	**Suicidal**: Attack regardless of the odds.

12.2. Unit Combat Values

The combat tables use a **10x internal scale**. That keeps attrition granular and lets crippled light ships keep contributing fire.

Unit	AS	DS	Notes
Destroyer	10	5	Agile glass cannon
Cruiser	30	30	Balanced brawler
Battleship	90	100	Primary battle line
Scout	0	10	Non-combat hull
Transport	0	10	Non-combat hull
ETAC	0	20	Colonization hull
Starbase	100	120	Heavy orbital defender
Battery	90	20	Planetary defense
Army	10	10	Ground combatant

12.3. Force Ratio to CRT Column

Force Ratio	CRT Column
`< 0.5`	Disadvantaged
`0.5 .. < 1.0`	Pressed
`1.0 .. < 1.5`	Even
`1.5 .. < 3.0`	Advantaged
`>= 3.0`	Overwhelming

12.4. Space / Orbital CRT

d10	Disadvantaged	Pressed	Even	Advantaged	Overwhelming
0	0.00	0.25	0.50	0.75	1.00
1	0.25	0.50	0.75	1.00	1.25
2	0.25	0.50	1.00	1.25	1.50
3	0.50	0.75	1.00	1.25	1.50
4	0.50	0.75	1.00	1.50	1.75
5	0.50	1.00	1.25	1.50	1.75
6	0.75	1.00	1.25	1.50	2.00
7	0.75	1.00	1.50	1.75	2.00
8	1.00	1.25	1.50	1.75	2.00
9	1.00	1.50	1.75	2.00	2.50

12.5. Column Shifts and Hit Formula

- Mixed `DD/CA/BB` fleet: `+1` CRT column
- Defending starbase in orbital combat: `+1` CRT column
- Withdrawal exchange: fixed `Pressed` column
- Final columns are clamped to the table bounds

```
hits = ceil(total_AS * CRT_multiplier)
```

An unmodified `9` on the `d10` is a critical hit and forces one extra bypass loss allocation.

12.6. Bombardment and Planetary Fire

Only destroyers, cruisers, and battleships contribute bombardment attack strength:

- Destroyer bombardment AS: `0.5x`
- Cruiser bombardment AS: `1.0x`
- Battleship bombardment AS: `1.5x`

Planetary return fire is:

```
return_fire_AS = battery_AS
```

Planetary return fire from batteries uses the **focus fire** rule. Hits bypass the crippled state and allocate directly to the destroyed pool by paying the full `2x DS` cost per ship.

Orbital hits on a world pay each target's DS on the same 10x scale:

- Ground battery: `20` hits
- Army: `10` hits
- Ship in the stardock: its own DS from the unit table (docked batteries `20`, armies `10`)
- Stored goods and factories: remaining hits are divided by `10`, and each point then destroys `100` stored goods and `1` factory

Hits below one unit's cost do not destroy it, and partial hits do not carry over to the next round. Hits too few for the next docked item pass on to the next stardock entry. Invasion suppression and blitz cover fire pay the same battery cost.

Each bombardment turn runs three rounds:

- **Rounds 1–2 (Suppression):** Attacker hits target stardock contents, then batteries. Batteries fire back each round. Armies, stored goods, and industry is shielded.
- **Round 3 (Breakthrough):** If batteries reached zero before this round, attacker hits cascade into armies, stored goods, and industry. If batteries still stand, round 3 is another suppression exchange.

Invasion uses one suppression exchange against batteries. If batteries are cleared, the softening pass targets armies only — industry and stored goods are not damaged during invasion. Its CRT column compares bombardment AS against `armies x 10`. Orbital softening may destroy at most half of the defender's starting armies, ensuring a meaningful landing battle whenever a world began the assault with a garrison. Once armies land, ground combat in invasion and blitz proceeds in repeated simultaneous CRT rounds until one side is destroyed. The defender receives a `+1` column bonus in those ground rounds, and a final exchange cannot produce a draw: the larger force entering that exchange survives with a remnant army, with exact equality favoring the defender.

13. Appendix C: Preservation and Original Sources

This edition preserves the game in a playable modern form. The aim is simple: keep the campaign rules legible, playable, and documented.

13.1. Source Hierarchy

This manual is the authoritative player manual for the Rust edition of Nostrian Conquest.

The preserved originals in `original/v1.5/` remain historical references and an ambiguity fallback:

- `ECQSTART.DOC` — Quick-start guide
- `ECPLAYER.DOC` — Detailed player manual
- `ECREADME.DOC` — Release and package information
- `ECGAME.EXE` — The original 1992 player client
- `ECMAINT.EXE` — The original yearly maintenance program
- `ECUTIL.EXE` — The original sysop utility for game initialization and management

13.2. Preservation Policy

- This manual is the authoritative player-facing manual for the Rust edition.
- The original manuals are preserved historical references and an ambiguity fallback for classic intent and terminology.
- The original DOS binaries remain the final compatibility check.
- This edition keeps the player-visible classic behavior that matters.
- When an exact classic formula is still unknown, this manual states the rule plainly instead of pretending otherwise.
- When the preserved originals clarify an ambiguity, that clarification should be folded back into the current manuals/specs rather than left only in the legacy `.DOC` set.

13.3. BBS Drop File Compatibility

Rust BBS hosting uses `nc-door`, not the old DOS binary path. It reads `DOOR32.SYS`, `DOOR.SYS`, and `CHAIN.TXT` directly. For a player, the practical point is simple: log into the board, launch the door, and play. If you are the sysop, see the **Sysop Manual** for setup details.

13.4. This Manual

This manual combines the original player guidance with the appendix reference tables in Section 11, Section 12, and Section 14. The main body stays player-facing. The appendices collect formulas, tables, and list-screen codes.

14. Appendix D: Table Filtering and Sorting

The main list screens all use the same command-line filter system. This lets you cut a long table down to the exact rows you want instead of paging through dead weight.

One filter is active at a time on each table. If you choose a new filter, it replaces the old one. If a filter matches nothing, the table stays filtered and tells you no rows match.

14.1. Filtering Procedure

1. Open the table you want.
2. Press `F`.
3. Type the column code, the visible column name, or the shortest unique prefix, and press `Enter`.
4. Type the value for that column and press `Enter`.
5. Type `all` at the column prompt to clear the current filter.

NOTE: `Q` or `Esc` cancels the current filter prompt without changing the active filter.

If your prefix matches more than one code, the command line stays open and shows the matching codes so you can narrow the entry.

14.2. Value Rules

- **Text columns:** Enter plain text. Matching is case-insensitive and looks for that text anywhere in the cell.
- **Number columns:** Enter a bare number for an exact match, or use `>`, `>=`, `<`, `<=`, `=`, or `!=`.
- **Coordinate columns:** Enter `xx,yy` for one exact sector, or `xx,yy/r` for a radius filter.
- **Database unknown values:** Enter `?` to match worlds where that value is still unknown.

Examples:

- Fleet list, `ord`: `holding`
- Fleet list, `sel`: `yes`
- Fleet list, `roe`: `>=4`
- Planet list, `coo`: `12,7/3`
- Total planet database, `own`: `#3`
- Total planet database, `max`: `>=100`

14.3. Sorting Procedure

1. Open the table you want.
2. Press `S`.
3. Type the column code, the visible column name, or the shortest unique prefix, and press `Enter`.
4. Press `S` again and submit the same code, or just press `Enter` on the default code, to flip `ASC`/`DESC`.

NOTE: On the Total Planet Database, `rng` or `range` is also accepted at the sort prompt to sort by distance from a chosen sector.

The active sort and active filter both appear in the table title.

14.4. Fleet List Codes

Code	Column	Notes
`id`	Fleet ID	Fleet number
`loc`	Location	Current sector
`ord`	Order	Also accepts `holding`, `moving`, and `combat`
`tar`	Target	Mission target sector
`spd`	Speed	Current speed
`eta`	ETA	Text match on the ETA column
`roe`	ROE	Rules of engagement value
`ars`	Armies	Loaded armies
`shi`	Ships	Ship and force summary text
`sel`	Selected	Use `yes` or `no`

14.5. Planet List Codes

Code	Column	Notes
`coo`	Coord	Planet coordinates
`pla`	Planet	Planet name
`max`	Max	Maximum production
`cur`	Curr	Current production
`trs`	Points	Stored treasury points
`bdg`	Bdgt	Build budget
`rev`	Rev	Revenue
`gro`	Grow	Growth
`bui`	Queue	Build queue size
`sta`	Dock	Docked ships
`sbs`	SBs	Friendly starbases
`ars`	ARs	Planet armies
`gbs`	GBs	Ground batteries

14.6. Total Planet Database Codes

Code	Column	Notes
`coo`	Coord	World coordinates
`pla`	Planet	Known planet name
`own`	Owner	Known owner text such as `#3` or `Unowned`
`max`	Max	Known maximum production
`see`	Seen	Last year seen
`ars`	ARs	Known armies
`gbs`	GBs	Known ground batteries
`sbs`	SBs	Known starbase count
`cur`	Curr	Known current production
`trs`	Points	Known stored points
`sco`	Scout	Last scout year